

FACETING A DIAMOND

When mined, gemstones often look dull; they must be cut and polished to shine. The best way to maximize the beauty of a transparent gem is to cut the surface into a series of flat, reflective faces called facets.



MINING

Gemstones are found in different areas across the world. They are sometimes brought to the Earth's surface by volcanic eruptions.



BIGGEST GEMS

Gemstones can be huge. The Olympic Australis opal weighs 3.45 kg (7.5 lb); the American Golden topaz is 4.57 kg (10 lb); and the largest colourless diamond, the Cullinan, is 10 cm (4 in) long.



ORGANIC GEMSTONES

Organic gemstones are made from animal or plant materials. For instance, coral is formed from sea creatures, pearls develop in certain shellfish such as oysters, and amber is made of fossilized tree resin.

